

sum, but it's better than nothing, and it could begin to give you many of the benefits of having a family fortune.

For example, you may not want to live on \$30,000 per year, but you could if you had to. That alone is a great thing, because it means that if you wanted to do so you could be free to pursue some interest that was not immediately financially rewarding. Or you could use the money to become more independent and secure in other ways—perhaps by simply insulating your house, paying off a mortgage early or saying “F-U” to the whole world.

Obviously, you could always simply improve your standard of living by spending the \$30,000 or by letting it accumulate. In just three years of accumulation, you could add nearly \$100,000 to your wealth. In 10 years, you'd have \$400,000 more.

WHAT KIND OF MONEY IS FAMILY MONEY?

Apart from how you get it . . . and what you do with it, we'll also note that family money tends to hang out in different places than other kinds of wealth. As we'll see in Chapter 5, the investments you make are different. But also the nature of the wealth itself tends to be different.

Probably the most agreeable way to build a family fortune is just to own something you like owning that subsequently becomes very valuable. That happens from time to time.

You might, for example, have a painting hanging on your wall. Perhaps it was given to you by your grandmother, who bought it from a starving artist in Paris just after World War II. You like the painting. You like it even more when it turns out to be a forgotten painting by Picasso.

Sometimes art goes wild. An artist may struggle to survive, giving his paintings away for a bowl of soup or a glass of wine. Years later, for no reason that bears much analysis, the artist becomes a sensation. His works fetch millions.